INDIAN NAVY

GENDER NEUTRAL FROM TOPMAST

By Pradip R. Sagar



PRIDE OF PLACE
Indian Navy officers on the flight deck of INS *Vikrant*

After opening its doors to women on warships and its combat units—first as officers and then as sailors/ other ranks—the Indian Navy is now sailing towards reducing 'gender stereotyping' by adopting gender-neutral language in its official communication. The navy believes that after the induction of women in all its branches, both as officers and as Agniveers, there is a requirement for adopting gender-neutral language in all official correspondence, policy documents and internal communication. According to figures provided by the ministry of defence in Parliament, 7,093 women personnel are serving in the Indian Army at present, followed by 1,636 in the Indian Air Force and 748 in the Navy.

Taking a cue from the European Parliament's guidelines for gender-neutral language in 2008 and 2018, the naval headquarters has come out with a detailed communiqué. Other countries' navies, too, have been seeing a change in this regard. In August 2020, the Canadian navy introduced gender-neutral designations in an effort to be more inclusive, and replaced 'seaman' with 'sailor' over all ranks. Thus, former designations like Leading Seaman and Master Seaman were changed to Sailor First Class and Master Sailor, respectively.

From now on, the Indian Navy, the world's sixth-largest naval force, will use such gender-neutral titles as 'Mess Staff', 'Service Person' and 'Navigator's/ Gunner's/ Communication Assistant' in lieu of the older 'Messman', 'Serviceman' and 'Yeoman', respectively. In addition, they will follow other neutral words gradually gaining ground in civil society, like 'humanity' for 'mankind' and 'actor' for 'actress'.

The navy believes that the purpose of gender-neutral language is to avoid

EQUALITY ABOARD

From now on, gender-privileged terms are jettisoned from the Indian Navy's lexicon. More gender-equal terms are in

OLD	NEW
Manning Plan	Staffing Plan
Action Manning	Action Staffing
Manholes	Maintenance holes
Messman	Mess Staff
Yeoman	(Trade) Assistant: for example, Navigator's Assistant, Gunner's Assistant, Communication Assistant
Serviceman	Service person
Ex-serviceman	Veteran/ Ex-service person
Manpower	Workforce or Human Capital
Chairman	Chairperson or Chair
Spokesman	Spokesperson